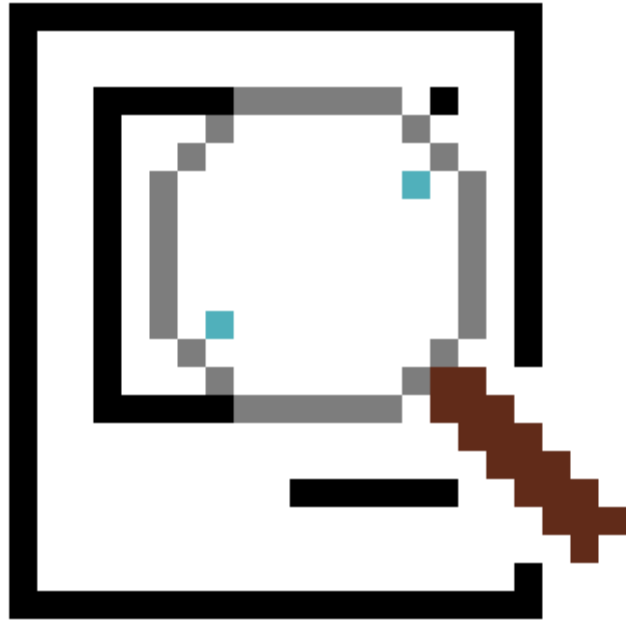




(Im)Material Problems. Challenges in Researching AI with Digital Methods (in the Time of AI)

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EASST2026: More than now:
exploring resilient futures
8-11 Sept 2026, Kraków



1. Three methodological challenges of researching AI with digital methods:
material; temporal; epistemological challenges
2. What do we mean by material, temporal, and epistemological challenges
3. Situate our research against the broader “AI” research
4. The objectives of three different case studies & how the material, temporal, and epistemological challenges transpired
5. Potentiality of digital methods as analytical entry points to AI critique & ways of ‘meeting’ these three challenges



1. the material challenge

the lack of access to the internal strategies and agendas of Big Tech
and the limited access to collect and analyse code and data

2. the temporal challenge

the unreliable tracking of changes in AI models and their outputs and
their movements as SM content

3. the epistemological challenge

the shrinking (archival) knowledge spaces that offer alternative
stories and narratives



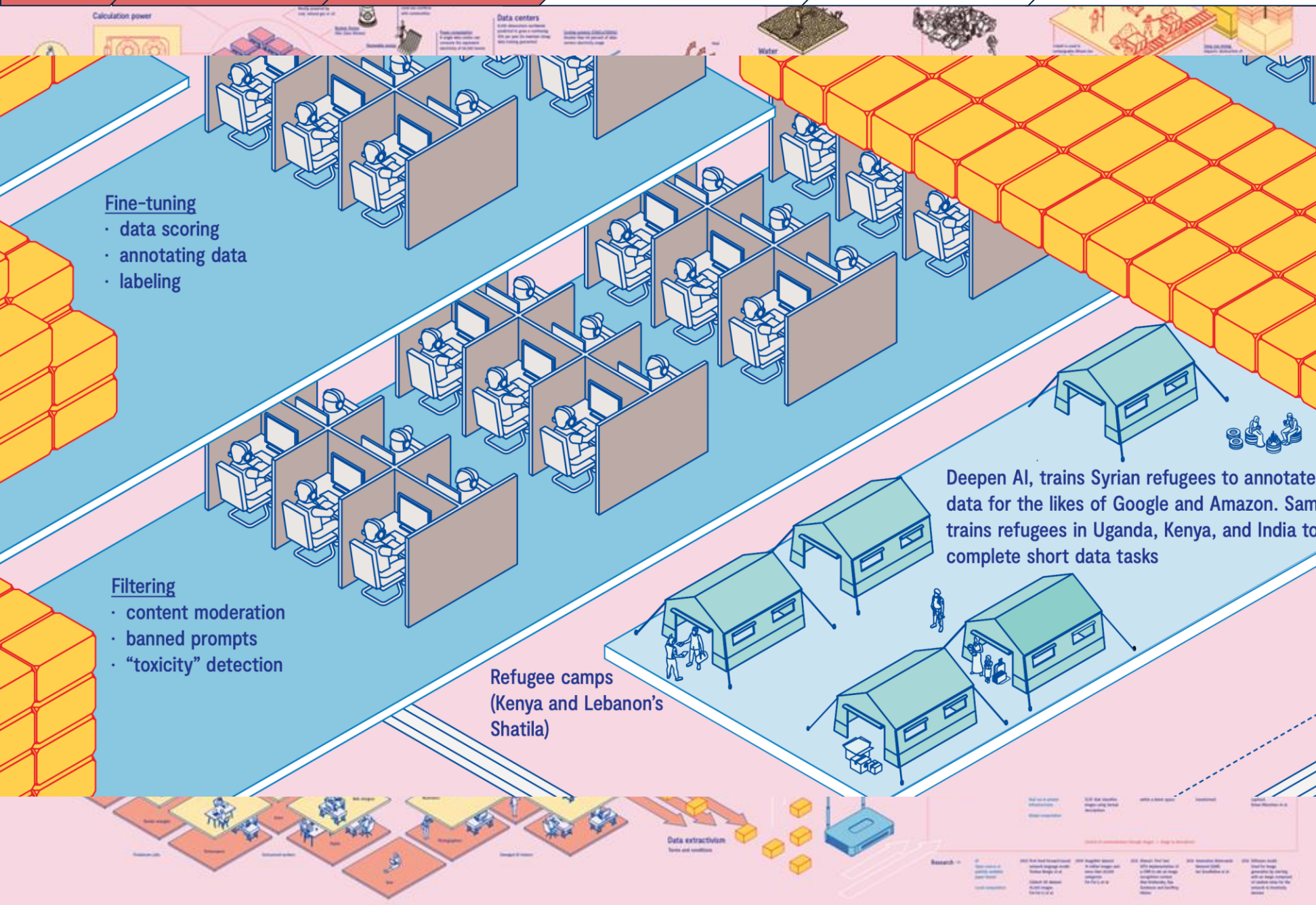
1. the material challenge

We've seen those challenges already - for a very long time.

2. the temporal challenge

These challenges don't seem to be going away anytime soon.

3. the epistemological challenge



ToC

Definitions

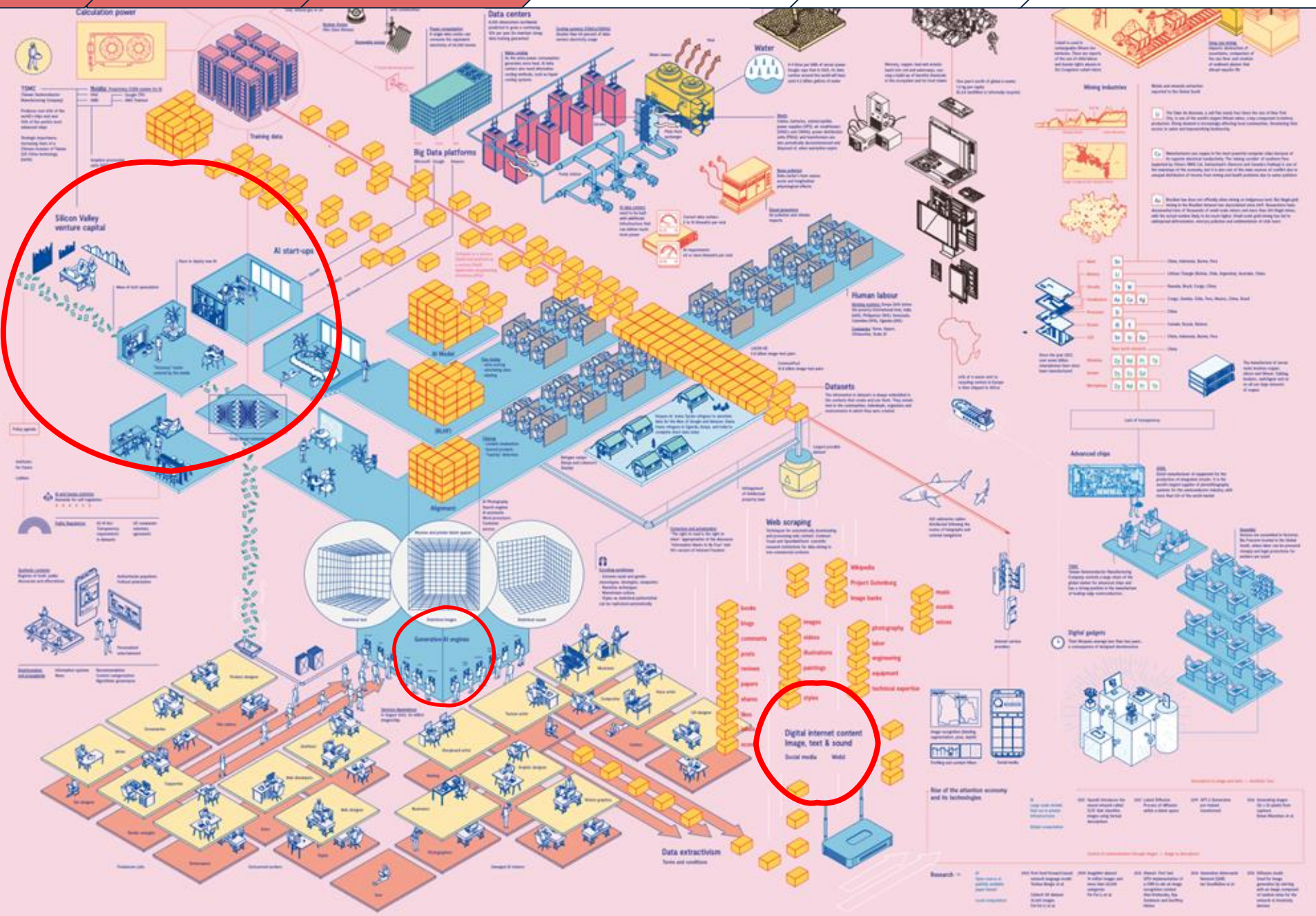
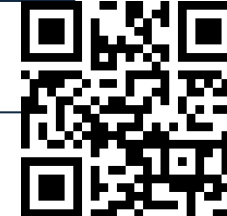
Context

Material

Temporal

Epistemological

Conclusions



Research and map design @tallerestampa
<https://cartography-of-generative-ai.net/>



OpenAI

OpenAI fires co-founder and CEO Sam Altman for allegedly lying to company board

AI firm's board said Altman was 'not consistently candid in his communications with the board' and had lost its confidence

- Interview: Sam Altman on whether AI will save humanity - or destroy it

Stanusć, N., & Rogers, R. (2026).
How AI is imagined by industry during
the Sam Altman controversy.
New Media and Society.
doi.org/10.1177/14614448261419109

Article

How AI is imagined by industry during the Sam Altman controversy

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Abstract

The aim of this research is to identify AI imaginaries, the issues they raise, and how the AI industry tackles them. It does so by choosing an opportune moment to map the issue space by virtue of a controversy around the firing and rehiring of OpenAI CEO Sam Altman. The sites for the mapping are X/Twitter and LinkedIn, where users frantically post not only about Altman but also about all manner of AI promises and pitfalls. By employing techniques from controversy mapping and digital research methods, we locate contemporary AI imaginaries, assess their salience in a cross-platform perspective, and describe the stakes gleaned from the prominence of certain dominant imaginaries, such as longtermism, regulatory ambivalence, and techno-hagiography. We discuss the issues these imaginaries raise and the AI industry's premediation and preclusion of them: the manners by which the AI industry strives to occupy the future and absorb the present.

Keywords

Artificial intelligence, controversy mapping, digital methods, imaginaries, longtermism, regulatory ambivalence

Introduction: AI industry reaction to the Sam Altman controversy

A little less than a year after the release of ChatGPT, OpenAI, the company behind the groundbreaking chatbot, was in the spotlight again. But this time, it was not because



new media & society

1–19

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Here's a timeline of the OpenAI saga with CEO Sam Altman

First, they fire him. Then, he "joins" Microsoft. Now, Sam Altman is back as CEO of OpenAI. How did this happen?

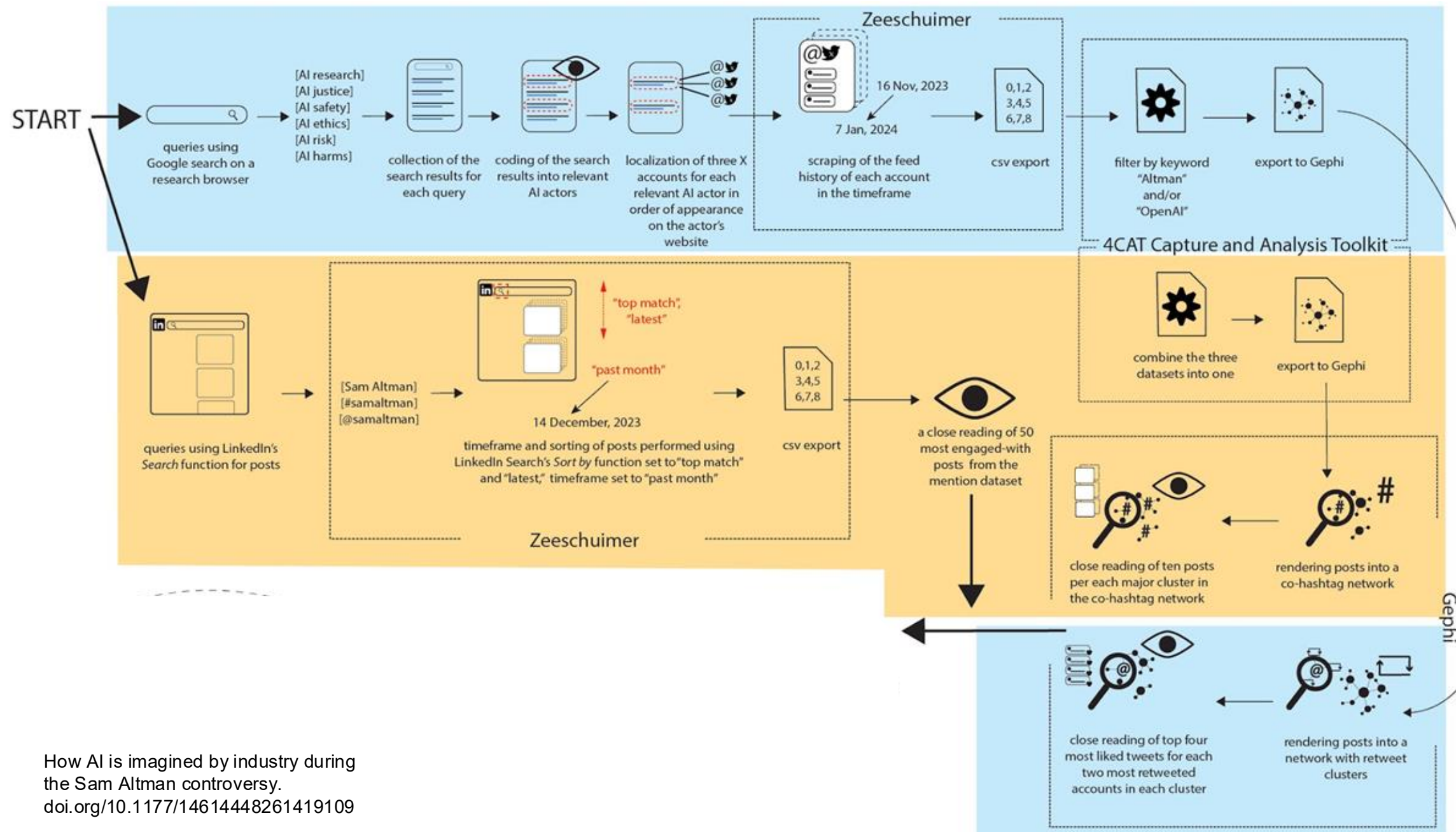
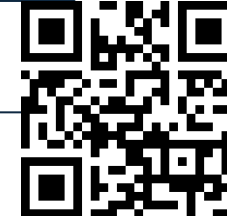
Matt Binder on November 22, 2023

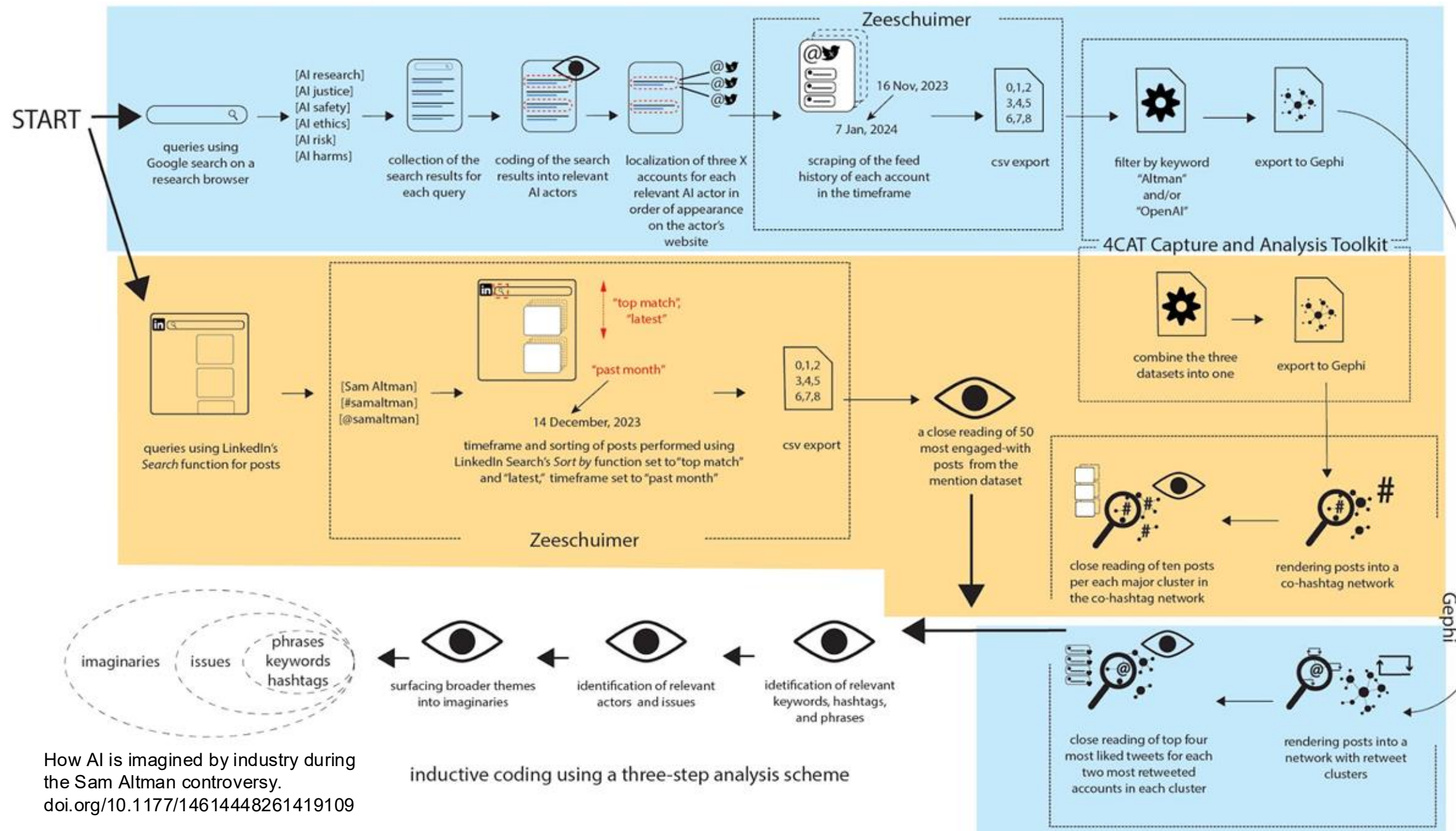
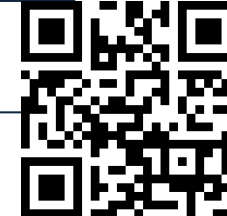


Altman Returns as CEO to OpenAI Only Days After Firing

The move appears a victory for Altman and Microsoft.









- the application programming interface (API) access – non-existent, otherwise unreliable
- scraping – inconsistent, tricky - esp. with Musk's X
- subject to platform's unclear content ordering & ranking
- we turn to imaginaries and the issues that they raise as methodological aids

Article



How AI is imagined by industry during the Sam Altman controversy

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What Do Deepfakes Want? Using 'Digital Forensic Gaze' and Digital Methods to See (like) Deepfakes

Team Members

Facilitators: Natalia Stanusch, Richard Rogers

Design Facilitators: Noemi Capparelli, Luca Bottani

Participants: Emma Garzoino, Marius Liedtke, Deborah Nyangulu, Omer Rothenstein, Chufan Huang, Michelle Stewart, Shuyu Zhang, Quyang (July) Zhao

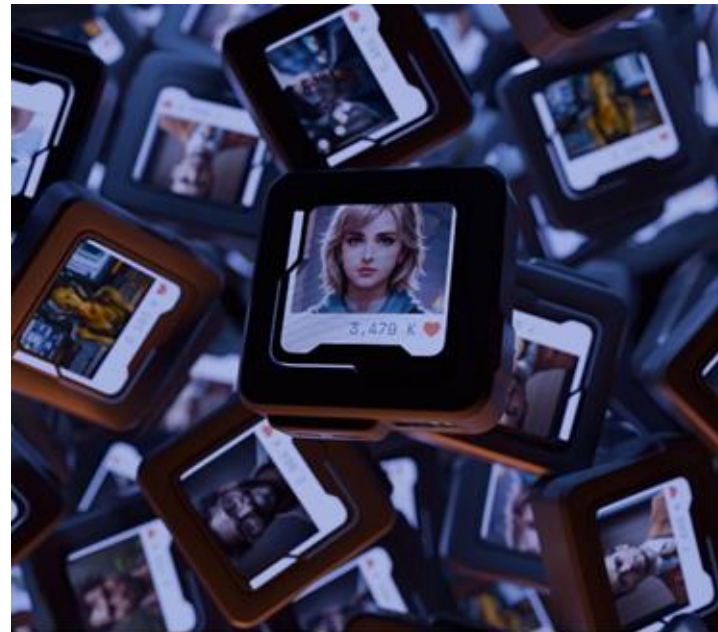
Links

[posters](#)

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- [3. Methodology](#)
- [4. Findings](#)
- [5. Discussion](#)
- [6. Conclusions](#)
- [7. References](#)

Stanusch, N., & Rogers, R. (2024). What Do Deepfakes Want? Using the 'Digital Forensic Gaze' and Digital Methods to See (like) Deepfakes. *Digital Methods Initiative*.
<https://www.digitalmethods.net/Dmi/SummerSchool2024WhatDoDeepfakesWant>

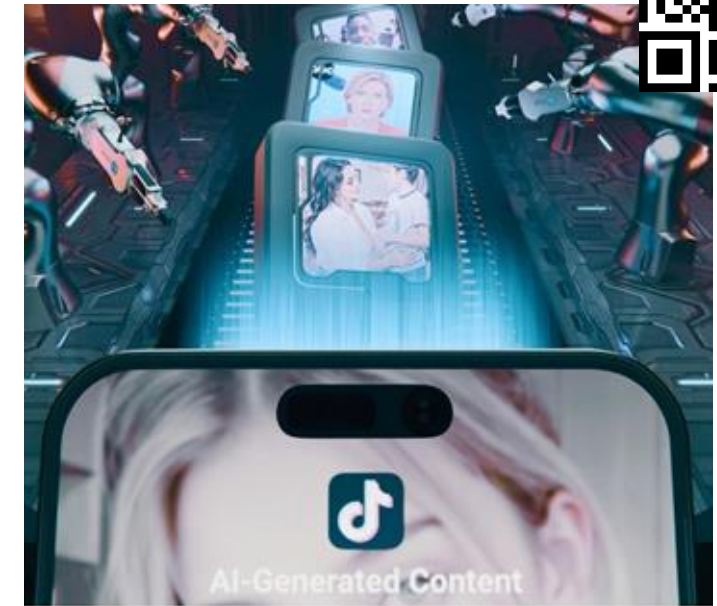


AI - GENERATED ALGORITHMIC VIRALITY

How synthetic AI imagery and agentic AI accounts try to game TikTok and Instagram.

AI FORENSICS

AI Forensics (2025). Generating Algorithmic Virality: How synthetic AI imagery and agentic AI accounts try to [game](#) TikTok and Instagram.
<https://aiforensics.org/work/gen-ai-slop>

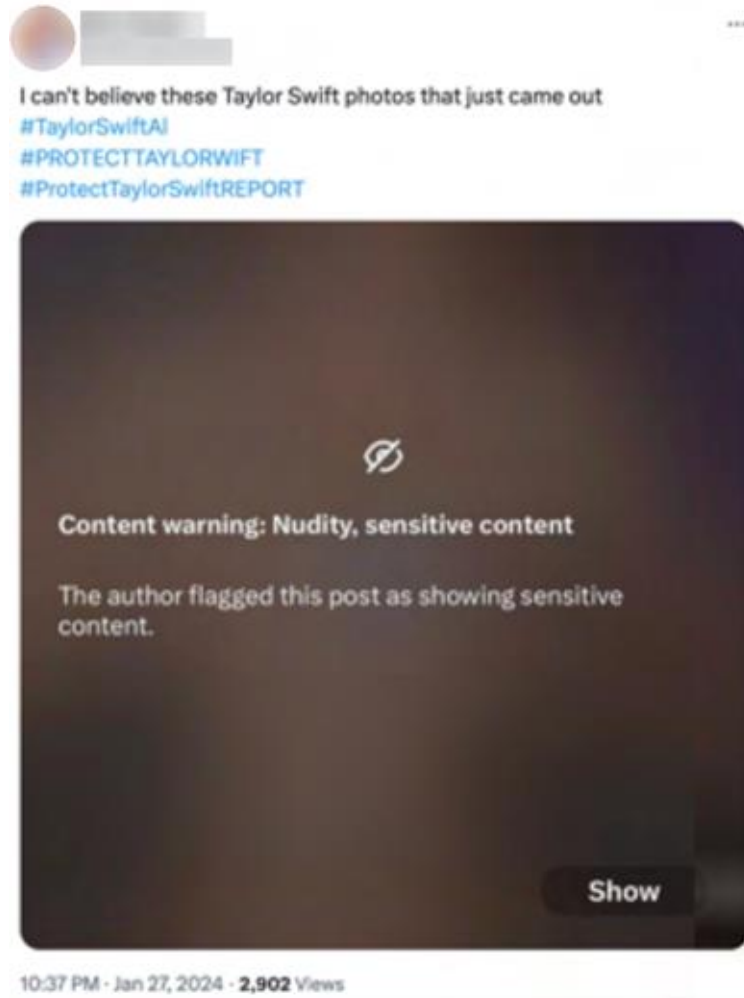


PROMPT , UPLOAD , REPEAT :

How Agentic AI Accounts
Flood TikTok With
Harmful Content

AI FORENSICS

AI Forensics (2025). Prompt, Upload, Repeat: How Agentic AI Accounts Flood TikTok with Harmful Content.
https://doi.org/10.33767/osf.io/fue3z_v1



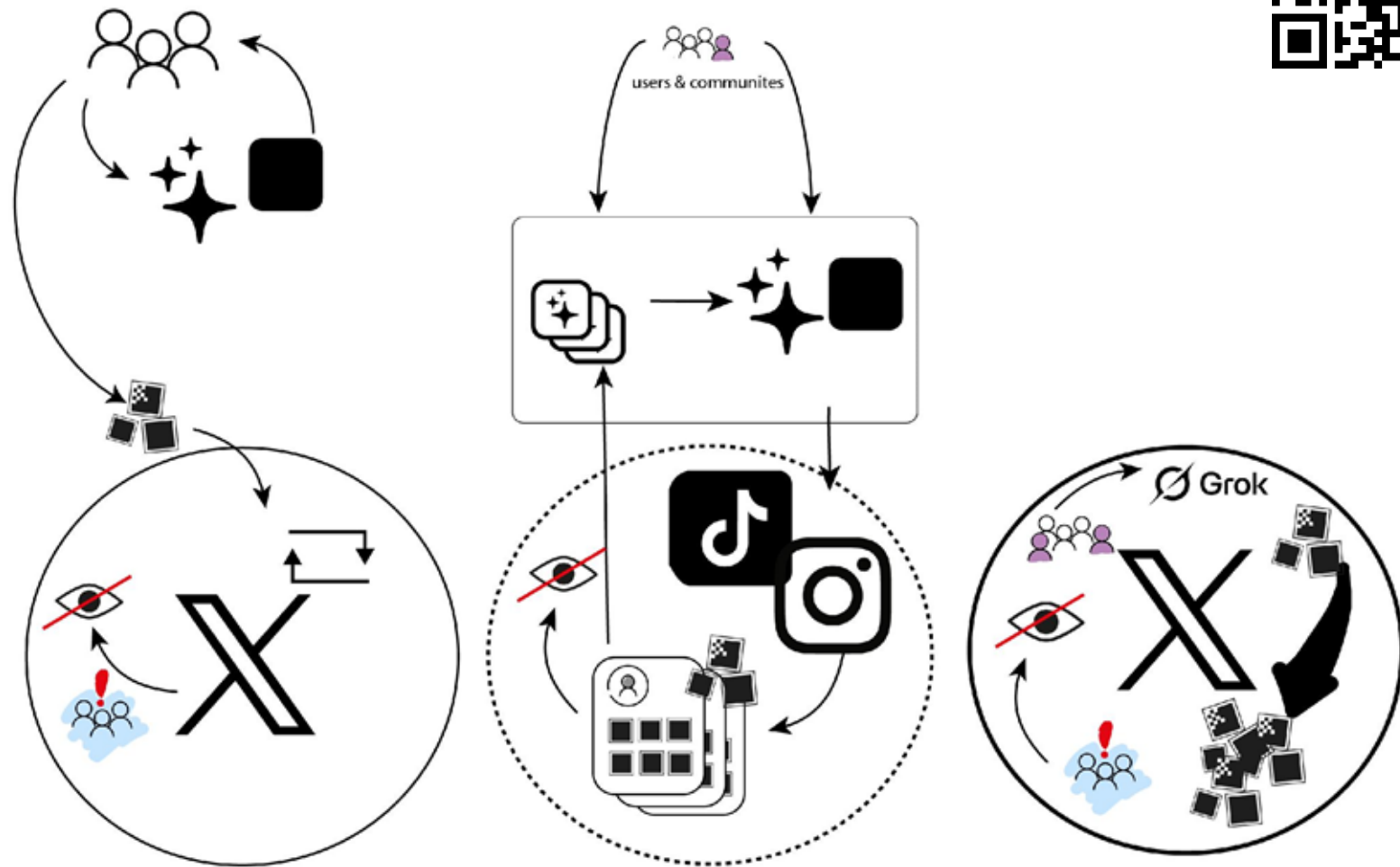
AI Forensics. (2026). Grok Unleashed: Grok Generating Flood of Sexualized Images of Women, Including Minors, and Extremist Propaganda.
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<https://www.digitalmethods.net/Dmi/SummerSchool2024WhatDoDeepfakesWant>

AI Forensics (2025). Prompt, Upload, Repeat: How Agentic AI Accounts Flood TikTok with Harmful Content.
https://doi.org/10.33767/osf.io/fue3z_v1



- the unreliable tracking of changes in AI models and their outputs and their movements as SM content
- genAI content, agentic capabilities, and preexisting SM pitfalls make the platform vernaculars grow darker - both morally and methodologically
- 'Dark (AI) vernaculars,' where AI-generated content *lives* both on and off the platforms



Stanusć, N., & Rogers, R. (2024). What Do Deepfakes Want?
<https://www.digitalmethods.net/Dmi/SummerSchool2024WhatDoDeepfakesWant>

AI Forensics (2025). Prompt, Upload, Repeat: How Agentic AI Accounts Flood TikTok with Harmful Content.
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Artificial Intelligence And Its Collective Ideation: Doing A Media Archaeology On Wikipedia

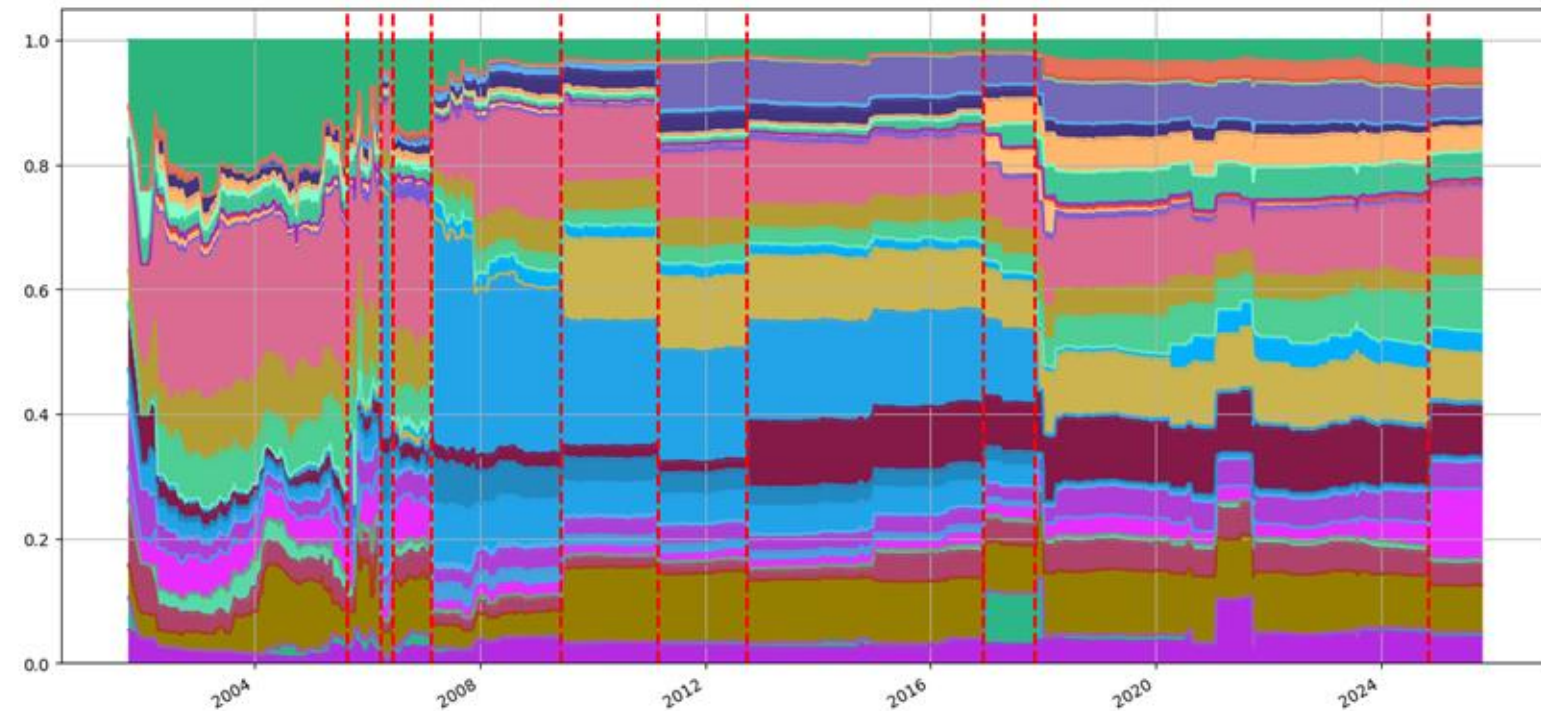


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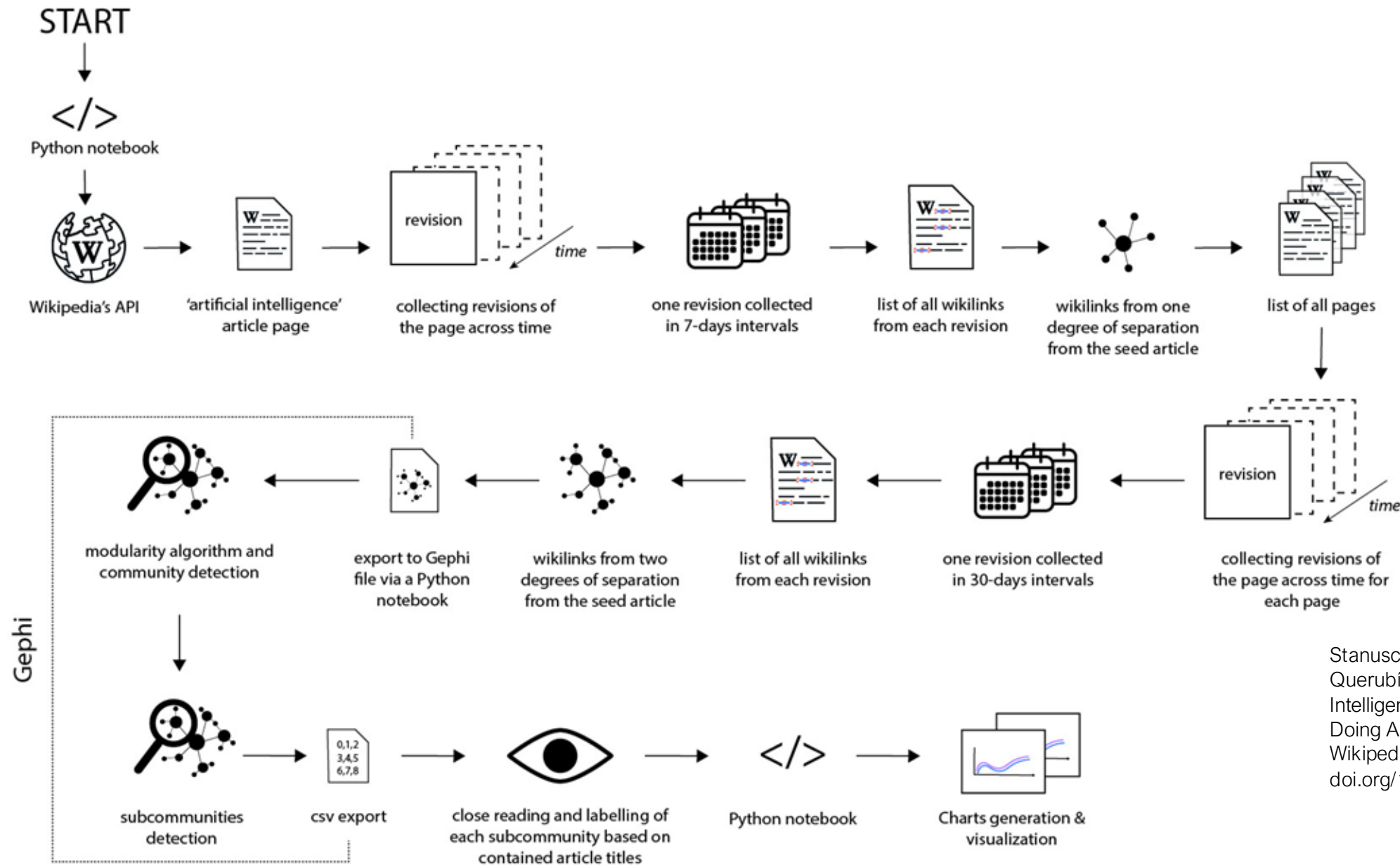
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| 10 - Computer-assisted Engineering & Sciences | 42 - N/A |
| 11 - Genetic Algorithms & Bio-Inspired Optimization | 43 - Generative AI, LLMs, and & Deep Learning |
| 12 - Knowledge Representation, Programming Languages, and Computing Fields | 44 - AI as a Broader Research Field & its Critique |
| 20 - Biology | 50 - Inventions |
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| 22 - Engineering & Computer Science Glossaries | 52 - Technological Inventions (Computer-based Hardware and Engineering) |
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| 41 - Machine Learning | 82 - Logic, Reasoning & Philosophy of Mathematics |

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- Ownership, technological, & ideological imperatives pose a risk of flattening or steering the alternative histories and knowledge spaces
- Archiving of web as larger and uncertain project



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Material, temporal, and epistemological challenges have been with us for a very long time.

AI technologies are reinstituting the classic problems of studying new media.

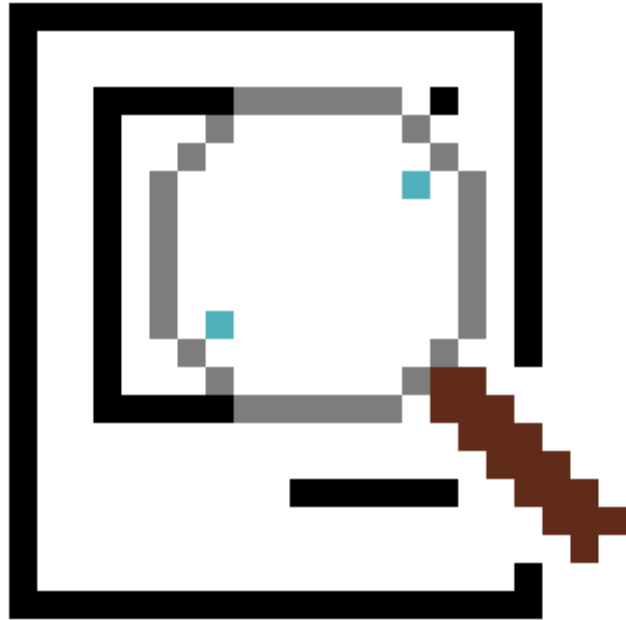
While these challenges have been met, they remain and will continue to pose obstacles as they are getting more problematic.



Challenges partially met:

1. Through the moment of controversy we were able to track and stabilize AI imaginaries
1. Through the insights from platform studies, we were able to observe AI as platform content to be moderated that lives in dark vernaculars
1. Through the media archaeological gaze, we were able to view 'disruptive' AI as continuity and just an application across Wikipedia's own view of AI ruptures and periods

We join with others in meeting these challenges, and in turning the AI-evoked methodological challenges into research opportunities



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